



Fun Fact

During the process of photosynthesis, plants emit light, called fluorescence, that humans aren't able to see.



Honour served

NASA's Kepler Mission team received the Smithsonian's highest honour
<http://dgit.in/NASAKepSmith>

NAS

designed user interfaces that we've come across. There are up to ten options for the user to fiddle with and there are explanations listed for each option. Moreover, the interface guides the user through processes. For example, let's say you wish to create a new share folder then the almost all devices will produce an error message but few will actually open up the folder creation panel in the control panel and let you know that this is how you go about a process and this is where you start from. However, Synology's lineup is comparatively expensive which explains the amount of effort expended in the UI.

With about 75 apps available for the DSM, Synology is quite the versatile NAS device. Setting up

THECUS N2310/ N4310

Both the N2310 and the N4310 are more budget friendly models. This doesn't mean that they don't offer good performance. We'll get to the performance bit later. The interface looks exactly the same with the only difference being the missing icons for features that are present in the N4310 and not on the N2310. Compared to the N2310 the N4310 has nine extra features. The overly simplistic interface works just fine but the lack of helpful explanations for different configuration settings might make configuring these units a daunting task. What makes things a little more irksome is that the support forums hardly show any activity with certain sections having no moderators at all. So if you do run into problems that can't be found on the forums then talking to support is the only way to go. The good thing about their products are

the sheer number of third party applications available. Out of a portfolio of 720 apps these two models support 69 each at the time of writing this article. One caveat is that you can't install all of these apps from the UI, rather you have to go to Thecus' website to get the third-party apps, and third party apps form the majority of their portfolio.

NETGEAR RN104

NETGEAR's user interface is quite similar to Synology's. It is quite simple to follow and is akin to an HTML page rather than the OS-like interface that Synology has. The overly simplistic interface can end up being a little too simple. So a power user might actually feel that the device is lacking but power users can always SSH into it to get more control. However, NETGEAR mentions explicitly that enabling root over SSH can be used as a reason to deny the user technical support. Like the other two brands, even NETGEAR makes available a well rounded portfolio of apps for you to extend the functionality of the NAS and you can install these apps straight from the UI itself.

WINNERS BEST PERFORMER

We chose RAID 0 in order to maximise the performance scores across the board and in our tests Synology's DS214play took the lead despite being a 2-bay NAS. This is why it wins the Best Performer Award in our test. It comes with a high price tag but going by what we've seen, it sure does give you your money's worth. It was followed by Thecus' N4310, N2310 and NETGEAR's RN104 came last. The DS214play was consistent in performance throughout the test, only NETGEAR's RN104

could trump it in one of the 14 tests. In fact, the RN104 scored quite high when data was being written to it. The drop in performance can be attributed to the SoC which didn't match up to the offerings from Intel and AMCC.

Thecus' N4310 did certainly perform consistently and scored higher than its little sibling, however, this can be attributed to the extra

Moreover, the fact that a device priced at ₹15,400 offers a capacity of 12TB led it to winning the Best Buy Award.

EDITOR'S PICK

For our Editor's Pick Award, we went with NETGEAR's RN104. While it might not have scored high in performance, it wasn't bad either. For a SOHO / home environment, this



Synology DS214play

two HDDs being in RAID 0. The N2310 isn't great but it isn't bad either. It was behind by only a few points and it costs less than half of when compared to the N4310. Keeping that in mind, it's a pretty good choice overall.

BEST BUY

When considering products for the best buy award we look at every single parameter and it is then weighed against the price tag. Since this test deals with storage devices, the net capacity on offer was weighed heavily in our final score. Needless to say, often the cheapest device on offer ends up bagging this award. Thecus' N2310 may have a bland interface but it has a feature set similar to the N4310 and even its performance scores were close by.

device not only provides a large storage pool but it also remarkably simple to setup. It was the only device to offer dual GbE ports with link aggregation. And need we go over its excellent build quality again? Having a massive feature set just doesn't cut it, ensuring that the average guy can easily make the most of those features is also crucial and NETGEAR's polished interface does just that. Then there is the fact that they offer a 3-year warranty program gives the RN104 an edge over its competitors.

Granted that we didn't have a lot of products in this comparison test, we did get some much needed insight into a product category that's on the rise. We'd like to hear your thoughts on the same and you can write in to us at editor@digit.in 